Mahindra University **HS 1101 – Module 1**
École Centrale School of Engineering **Worksheet 1.2**

Name: **Roll No:** **Batch:**

Pre-reading activity - Discuss the following questions in small groups or with a partner. You can use the space given below to make notes.

1. Can a person have many identities at the same time?
2. Have you ever felt that other people saw you differently from how you saw yourself?
3. Can identity change over time? Why or why not?

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Reading Strategy: STRAP

As you read, use the STRAP strategy.

STRAP Strategy for Reading	Think About
S – Subject	What is the text about?
T – Type	What form does the text take?
R – Role	What is the author's position (expert, instructor, student etc)?
A – Audience	Who is intended to read the material?
P – Purpose	What is the author's purpose? (to inform? to persuade? to share?)

During Reading - As you read *Identity Puzzle* by Nirupam Hazra published in The Telegraph Online, underline or highlight:

- words you do not know
- sentences that express the main argument
- examples that support the writer's ideas
- statements you agree or disagree with
- any questions that come to your mind

Identity Puzzle

Our inability to negotiate with identity in an agreeable manner has resulted in numerous conflicts



The question of identity assumes greater significance for its relational or reciprocal aspect. **File Photo**

'Who am I?' is probably the most ancient and profound question that kept sages and philosophers pondering for ages. However, this question also touches ordinary people when they try to make sense of life by relating to fellow human beings and society. While looking for an answer, one may stumble upon the question of identity.

Identity is the fundamental expression of our social existence based on our understanding, however imperfect or incomplete, of self and others. But it is not easy to define identity. The difficulty can be traced to its seemingly contradictory characteristics. Identity is intimately personal; at the same time, it shares ties with the larger collective existence. Identity can be fixed, yet amorphously fluid. It is erroneously conceived as monolithic even though it bears shades of multiplicity. Our inability to negotiate with identity in an agreeable manner has resulted in numerous conflicts. Human

history has also been a story that has revolved around identity — it tells how identity is shaped and shattered, valorised and vilified, subjugated and celebrated.

The question of identity assumes greater significance for its relational or reciprocal aspect. Its implication is not confined only to who I think I am; what others think I am becomes equally important. Identity thus turns into an object of assessment for both self and society which, in turn, gives birth to the perennial battle between individual and society.

Identity was, for long, seen to be biologically determined. It worked on the principle of immutability. Hence, it was not easy to break free from the prison of identity. However, in the course of time, it became apparent that identity can be retrieved and redefined. This realisation led to the old order being questioned. Gradually, it also became clear that identity has the potential to challenge and change existing social relations. Soon, identity and its rightful assertion started to inspire movements. The margin started to question the mainstream and the subjective experience of identity groups began to emerge out of the meta-narratives of the majority.

The concept of identity underwent further transformation in the 21st century. One of the contributing factors was the tryst of technological advancement with the biological aspect of identity. Modern technology, with its immense capacity to read and process vast amounts of information, has located identity in our bodily features: fingerprints, irises and even our faces have become bearers of identity. This had a liberating effect as identity based on the primordial ties of race, religion and caste began to weaken. Furthermore, social media bestowed the opportunity to construct identity according to one's fancy or cloak it in anonymity.

It was expected that the parochial conception of identity would become unsustainable. Yet, the 21st century has witnessed a surprising reassertion of majoritarian identity framed within the vocabulary of nation, race, religion and ethnicity. The reasons are varied. Some blame populist demagogues; others accuse neo-liberalism for triggering unequal competition; conservatives see it as a reaction to the onslaught of globalisation; those on the ideological-right explain it as a backlash against the overzealous defence of minority rights. However, all these explanations acknowledge that identity is redrawn according to changes in society.

It would be futile to attempt to straitjacket identity into a single framework. One individual carries multiple identities at the same time. To over emphasise one at the cost of all others will severely imperil individual freedom and social stability. So far as identity politics is concerned, there is nothing wrong in it as long as it does not take away the equal standing of others in society. Identity can be violently divisive and healingly integrative. It depends on us which one we opt for.

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Apply the STRAP Strategy - Answer the following in one or two sentences each.

1. **Subject:** Which aspect of identity does the article explore?
2. **Type:** What kind of text is *Identity Puzzle*?
3. **Role:** What role does the author play in presenting the ideas?
4. **Audience:** Who is the intended audience for this article?
5. **Purpose:** What does the author want readers to understand about identity?

Part I: Understanding Ideas - Finding the Main Idea

1. What is the central question around which the article is organised?

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2. Write the main idea of the article in one sentence.

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3. Which paragraph best expresses the writer's central argument? Give reasons.

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4. What does the writer want readers to understand about identity?

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Part II: Supporting Ideas - Complete the table with supporting evidence for the main ideas from the article *Identity Puzzle* by Nirupam Hazra.

Main idea	**Supporting evidence from the article**
Identity is complex.	
Identity changes over time.	
Technology influences identity.	
Identity can unite or divide people.	

Part III: Understanding the Writer's Organisation - How does the writer develop the discussion?

Number these stages in the order they appear.

_____ Identity in history
_____ Identity and technology
_____ Why identity is difficult to define
_____ Different explanations for identity politics
_____ Conclusion about multiple identities

Part IV: Personal Response - Choose one idea/message from *Identity Puzzle* that you think is the most important. Explain the idea in your own words and describe how it relates to your life or the world around you.

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